MASTERS OF BUSINESS ADMINISTRATION

SEMESTER 1



DMBA114

BUSINESS COMMUNICATION

Unit – 6

Developing Oral Business Communication Skills

TABLE OF CONTENTS

SL No	Topic	Fig No / Table / Graph	SAQ / Activity	Page No
1	Introduction	-	-	4 - 5
	1.1 Objectives	-	-	
2	Oral Communication	-	-	6 - 7
	2.1 Advantages of Oral Communication		1	
3	Types Of Oral Communication		-	8 - 9
4	Oral Business Presentations	I		10 - 28
	4.1 Steps in making oral presentations	1, 2	2	
	4.2 Using visual aids to support presentations	3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, II	3, I	
5	Summary	-	-	29
6	Glossary	-	-	30
7	Terminal Questions	-	-	31
8	Answers	-	-	32 - 33
9	Case Study	-	-	34 - 35
10	References	-	-	36

1. INTRODUCTION

In the previous unit, you learned the general principle of writing and principles of business writing. Irrespective of your field or the type of job that you choose to take up, you must develop good oral communication skills along with written skills. Oral communication is an important part of communication, whether it is in the form of a speech or proposal, both within and outside the organization. Oral skills are needed for making effective presentations, participating in and conducting meetings, dealing with customers, and interacting on a day-to-day basis with your superiors, peers, and subordinates within the organization. Your oral communication skills often reveal your personality. Speaking effectively also gives you great visibility and confidence and can contribute to your career success.

Kerka, S. in his book Job related basic skills (1990) writes, "The importance of workplace literacy has been underscored by the link between basic skills and productivity." Oral communication, listening,group effectiveness, interpersonal skills, negotiation and teamwork are identified among six job related basic skills sought by employers.

Maes, J. D., Weldy, T. G. & Icenogle, M. L. in their report A Managerial Perspective: Oral Communication Competency is Most Important for Business Students in the Workplace. Journal of Business Communication, 34, p67-80. states that "Results of two studies show that oral communication is the most important competency for college graduates entering the workforce." Their report identifies the oral skills most important for entry level graduates as: following instructions, listening, conversing, and giving feedback. In the first study, 354 managers identified and ranked the competencies and characteristics they consider when hiring college graduates for entry level positions. Findings revealed that the top three competencies are oral communication, problem solving, and self-motivation. Based on the first study, the second study revealed that the most important functions graduates perform are associated with oral communication competency such as handling customer complaints and meeting skills.

(Source: MORREALE, S.P., OSBORN, M.M., PEARSON, J.C. (2000). Why

Communication is Important: A Rationale for the Centrality of the Study of Communication. Journal of the Association for Communication Administration, 15, 16)

This unit helps you to answer the following questions:

What are the steps of effective oral communication? What is the use of visual aids in presentations?

In this unit, you will learn the advantages of oral communication in a business environment. You will also learn the art of developing presentations.

1.1 Objectives



After studying this unit, you should be able to:

- Explain the two types of oral communication skills
- List the types of presentations and their target audience
- List the steps for developing oral presentations
- Select visual and other presentation aids for maximum effect

2. ORAL COMMUNICATION

Oral communication refers to the exchange of information through spoken words, often accompanied by non-verbal cues like tone, facial expressions, and gestures. It is one of the oldest and most effective methods of communication, widely used in both personal and professional contexts. Oral communication can occur in various forms, including face-to-face conversations, telephone calls, video conferences, speeches, or group discussions.

This mode of communication is particularly valued for its immediacy. Unlike written communication, oral communication enables real-time interaction, allowing participants to provide instant feedback, clarify doubts, and engage in meaningful discussions. Its dynamic nature also allows for adjustments in tone, phrasing, or delivery based on the listener's reactions, making it a flexible and adaptive form of communication.

Oral communication plays a critical role in business contexts, including meetings, negotiations, presentations, and customer interactions. It fosters collaboration, builds personal connections, and ensures the efficient exchange of ideas. For example, a manager who provides verbal instructions to their team can address concerns immediately, ensuring clarity and alignment. However, oral communication also has limitations, such as the lack of a permanent record and the potential for misinterpretation if not delivered clearly. Despite these challenges, it remains an essential tool for conveying messages effectively, resolving issues quickly, and building strong professional relationships.

2.1 Advantages of Oral Communication

Oral communication is one of the most effective forms of interaction in business settings. It involves spoken words, whether in face-to-face conversations, telephone calls, or group meetings. It is widely used for discussions, negotiations, and conveying immediate information. The key advantages are as follows:

Clarity and Immediate Feedback: Oral communication allows for real-time clarification of doubts and misunderstandings, ensuring that messages are accurately understood by the receiver. It is particularly useful in situations requiring detailed instructions or complex discussions. For example, during a project briefing, a manager can verbally explain goals and timelines. Team members can immediately ask questions or seek clarifications, ensuring everyone is aligned.

Builds Personal Connections: Face-to-face communication fosters trust and strengthens relationships. The tone, facial expressions, and body language convey sincerity and empathy, making the interaction more impactful. For example, A sales executive meeting a client in person can build rapport, making it easier to negotiate and close a deal by addressing concerns directly.

Saves Time: Oral communication is faster than written communication for conveying messages and resolving issues. Immediate responses eliminate delays associated with emails or written correspondence. For example, A quick phone call between departments can resolve an urgent issue, such as clarifying stock availability, faster than an email chain.

Enhances Collaboration: Teamwork often thrives on oral communication. Group discussions, brainstorming sessions, and meetings encourage the free flow of ideas and foster a collaborative environment. For example, In a marketing team's brainstorming session, verbal exchanges of ideas lead to innovative campaign strategies, boosting creativity.

Flexibility in Tone and Delivery: Messages can be adapted on the spot based on the listener's reaction, making oral communication more dynamic and responsive. For example, A manager delivering feedback in a one-on-one meeting can adjust their tone to motivate an employee rather than demoralise them.

Oral communication is invaluable in business for its immediacy, personal touch, and adaptability. Whether used for negotiations, problem-solving, or team collaboration, its advantages lie in its ability to build relationships and ensure clear, efficient communication.

3. TYPES OF ORAL COMMUNICATION

In Unit 2, we learned that oral communication has some advantages compared to written communication. The advantages include personal quality, high interactivity, the possibility of making immediate contact and obtaining instantaneous feedback, and control over the receiver's attention.

Oral communication is classified into two types, oral face-to-face communication (for example, meetings and presentations) and oral non-face-to-face communication (for example, teleconferencing, telephone, and voice mail). While face-to-face meetings are more effective than non-face-to-face communication in most ways, they are expensive and impractical sometimes, due to the distance factor. Thanks to advances in technology, meetings today can still take place without being face-to-face, through teleconferencing. Teleconferencing allows participants at distant locations to speak and sometimes to see each other. Apart from the high cost and the difficulty in setting it up, teleconferencing has the same advantages as oral face-to-face communication.

For example, Walmart, the world's largest retailer, makes use of teleconferencing to keep its US headquarters in touch with store managers worldwide. Some headhunters also make use of the facility to conduct preliminary interviews and shortlist candidates based in other countries, before inviting them for a face-to-face interview.

Many multinational corporations and large Indian organizations also use this facility extensively.

Inspite of its advantages, teleconferencing will not replace face-to-face meetings completely, since it is unsuitable for certain types of communication that involve brainstorming, negotiations, persuasion and problem solving.

Telephone communication, another form of non-face-to-face communication, has the biggest advantage of being able to contact a receiver who it would be impossible to reach in person. Today, mobile phones have made it even easier to contact people who are on the move. Telephone communication also has a personal quality and permits the use of some non-verbal cues such as tone of voice, to enhance communication.

Voice mail is a type of telephone communication and is similar to an answering machine. Although it is generally inferior to speaking in person to the other party, it has some advantages. When you leave a recorded message, you can make your point felt and save time that might be wasted in exchanging pleasantries. Invitations can also be declined without having to give an explanation or reason or

having the other person talk back. Thus, there is greater control over how the message is composed and delivered. Besides, voice mail also makes it possible to keep a permanent record of the communication, unlike other types of oral communication. In spite of these advantages, however, voice mail has not caught on in India.

SELF-ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS – 1

True or False Questions:	
1	Conflicts between co-workers can be resolved through teleconferencing. (True/False)
2	Telephone communication has the advantage of providing immediate feedback. (True/False)
True or False Questions:	
3	_____will not replace face-to-face meetings completely.

4. ORAL BUSINESS PRESENTATIONS

Oral business presentations are a powerful way of presenting your ideas to others and are usually called for when a written memo or report is not sufficient to do the job. A written report tends to be less persuasive and may also be set aside without being read, whereas an oral presentation commands attention and fetches immediate feedback. Besides, approval for important ideas is rarely given without a face-to-face explanation.

Presentations may be made to internal audiences – superiors, peers, and subordinates, as well as to external audiences – consumers, intermediaries, bankers, suppliers, etc. Presentations may also be of different types, each with a different purpose. Some of the most common types of presentations and the audiences to whom they are addressed are mentioned in table 1

Table 1: Types of Presentation and Target Audience

Type/Purpose of Presentation	Example	Audience
Briefing and Information	New online leave application procedure	Employees
Orientation	Orientation to new joinees	Employees
Training	How to operate a new software	Employees
Reporting Research Findings	Consumer satisfaction survey	Superiors
Reporting Progress	Report on weekly sales	Superiors
Highlighting Company's Achievements	Reporting awards won by the Company	Media
TV and Radio Interviewsto describe Company Viewpoints	Describing the company's position on environmental issues	Society at large
Introduction	Overview of the company	New employees
Product Presentation	Highlighting features of a new product	Consumers, intermediaries

Project Proposal	New project was undertaken bythe company	Bankers
Policy Proposal	New mobile phone expense reimbursement policy	Superiors
Marking Special Occasions	Presentation at company anniversary celebrations	Internal and external audiences

4.1 Steps in making oral presentations

Table 6.1 indicates that oral presentations can range from simple to more complex ones, each with a different purpose. Irrespective of the nature of the presentation, the steps shown in figure 1 can be followed for planning and preparing an oral presentation.

Figure 1 depicts the steps for creating an effective oral presentation.

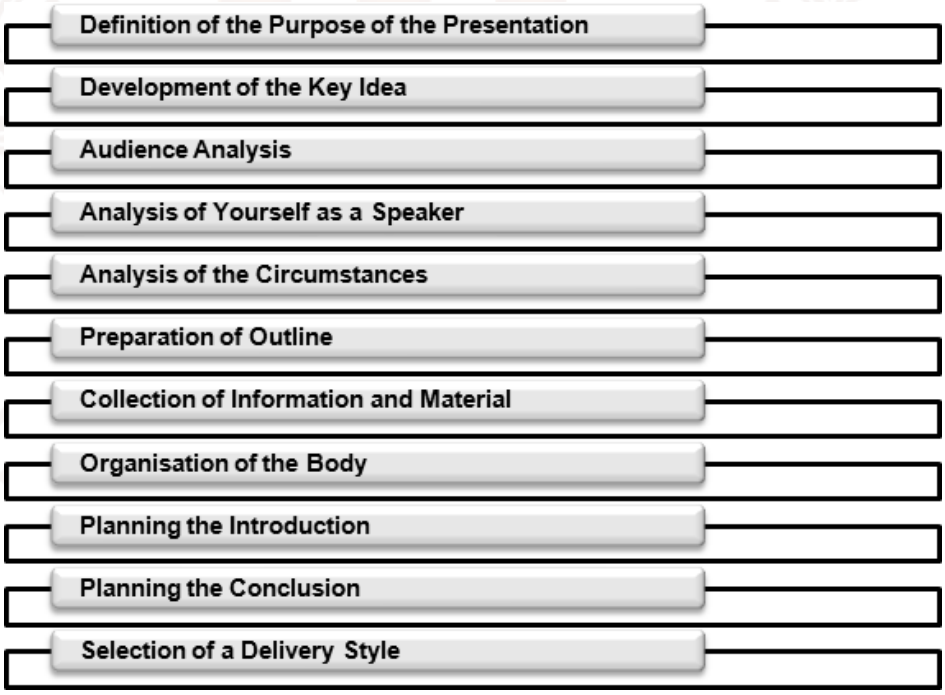


Figure 1: Steps for Creating Oral Presentation

Let us now study each of these steps in detail.

1. Definition of the purpose of the presentation

Before preparing for the presentation, it is important to be clear on the goal of the presentation. A 'statement of purpose', expressing what you want to achieve through the presentation must be framed so that it becomes easy to measure whether the goal has been accomplished or not.

The purpose of the presentation may be stated in broad or general terms or more specific terms. A 'general statement of purpose could be expressed in terms of one of the following:

- **To inform –** A presentation that seeks to inform would merely create awareness about developments and progress on specific fronts or try to spread knowledge about something new. In table 6.1, the first eight types of presentations are aimed at informing different audiences about something or the other – new procedures, new terminology, new software, findings of a study, sales progress, company achievements, viewpoints, and background.
- **To persuade –** A presentation that aims to persuade would try to change the attitude or behavior of the audience. It usually involves selling either a product or an idea. In table 6.1, the product presentation, project proposal, and policy proposal are all persuasive presentations. The product presentation seeks to persuade consumers to try a new product, the project proposal tries to persuade bankers to provide funds for a new project and the policy proposal tries to persuade top management to adopt a new policy of reimbursing mobile expenses.
- **To entertain –** A presentation with this purpose is meant to make the audience relax and have a good time. In table 6.1, presentations marking special occasions such as the company anniversary may merely focus on making people feel good about themselves.

Although it is useful to define the general purpose of a presentation, it is more important to frame a 'specific statement of purpose', which clearly spells out the answers to the following questions:

- Whom do I want to influence?
- What do I want them to do at the end of the presentation?
- How do I want them to do it?
- When do I want them to do it?
- Where do I want them to do it?

For example, "I want 50% of my prospective customers to be convinced enough to walk in to the store and try out the new product on a trial basis, within the next one week."

The statement of purpose in the previous example describes the reaction that you are seeking from your audience and also describes the goal in measurable terms. The number of customers who walk into the store and sample the product during the one-week period would indicate whether the goal has been achieved or not. As far as possible, the goal must be quantified, so that it is measurable.

Presentation goals must be realistic, keeping in mind the limitations of time, the topic of the presentation, and the nature of the audience. For example, a presentation that aims to train employees in the use of complicated software must not expect them to become experts at the end of the session.

2. Development of the key idea

The 'key idea' of a presentation is a statement that expresses the main message to be conveyed to the audience. It is different from a statement of purpose, which is generally meant for the presenter. The key idea is for the audience, and it is stated at the beginning of the presentation.

For example, if the purpose is to persuade a prospective customer to try out your company's vacuum cleaner, the key idea or message may be to explain how your brand is superior to other brands, feature for feature.

Once the key idea is clearly stated, it becomes easy to develop the rest of the presentation.

3. Audience analysis

Making a good presentation alone is not enough. It also has to be tailored to your listeners in such a way that they understand and appreciate it. The following 'information' must be 'gathered about your audience', even before you begin preparing for the presentation:

- **Job designations and areas of expertise –** You need to find out whether the audience comprises specialists in a particular area such as information technology or generalists. If they are specialists, your presentation could include technical aspects and jargon, which they would be able to understand. If not, you may have to make the presentation simpler or explain some of the terms elaborately.
- **Preferred style of presentation –** It would also be relevant to know the personal preferences of your audience, with regard to the style of presentation that they are most comfortable with. Some people may prefer a more informal or conversational style with some humor than a more formal style. Others may like the presentation to be made at a slower pace or they may prefer the presentation to be formal. However, you have to remember that humor must be used with

care so that it is relevant and does not offend the audience. Analyzing all this in advance would help in determining how the presentation must be delivered.

- **Demographic characteristics of the audience –** The gender, age, cultural background, and economic status of the audience also need to be studied in advance, so that the presentation may be tailored to appeal to that particular audience. For example, a financial planner addressing an audience comprising of senior citizens is likely to suggest investment options that would be different from those that might be suggested for a younger audience.
- **Size of the audience –** The size of the audience would determine your presentation style, the time set aside for questions and answers, the size of visuals, etc. With a smaller group, the presentation could be made less formal, the time for questions and answers could be reduced and the visuals could be made smaller, than for a larger group.
- **Level of knowledge on the subject –** You need to know how familiar your audience is with the subject of the presentation. If the audience comprises experts in that particular area, basic explanations may not be needed. On the other hand, if the level of familiarity is not so high, a lot of background information and explanation is required.
- **Attitude of the audience –** The attitude of your listeners, both towards you as a speaker and towards the topic of the presentation, needs to be studied in advance. If the audience is prejudiced towards you for some reason, you may have to alter your style of presentation considerably. If the presentation happens to be on a sensitive topic, you may have to proceed very tactfully. This is especially true of presentations that aim to persuade.

4. Analysis of yourself as a speaker

Apart from analyzing your audience, you also need to do a self-analysis to determine your own purpose of making the presentation, your level of knowledge on the subject and your feelings about the subject. As explained earlier, a clear statement of the specific purpose of the presentation must be developed. If you have a choice of subject, it is always better to speak on a subject on which you are an authority. If the choice is not given to you and you are less knowledgeable, then it is important to research the subject thoroughly, so that you are in a position to anticipate and answer any questions. Finally, you need to assess your feelings about the subject and make sure that you are convinced enough to be able to persuade others as well. This is similar to a salesperson being convinced about a product to be sold.

5. Analysis of the circumstances

This includes taking into consideration any limitations of infrastructure, time, and context that might affect your presentation. For example, if you are speaking in a small room where the lighting and acoustics are insufficient, you may have to overcome the limitations by altering the seating arrangement, using brighter visuals, and speaking loudly. If the presentation is to be made after lunch, you can include many attention grabbers in the presentation, to keep the audience alert. If you are making a presentation as part of a team, your style of presentation has to be consistent with that of your team members.

6. Preparation of outline

Once the initial groundwork is done, you must develop an outline of your presentation. Irrespective of the nature and purpose of the presentation, a standard format is generally followed. This includes the following:

- **Introduction –** This must include an 'attention getter' to get the audience involved and interested in the presentation. Several techniques may be used to command attention, which will be discussed later. The key idea or main message must be conveyed to the audience during the introduction.
- **Body or main section –** This is where the main points will be presented and elaborated upon. It is best to limit the number of main points to five, so as not to overload the listeners with too much information.
- **Conclusion –** A brief summary of the presentation, along with concluding remarks would be included in this section. The conclusion must have as much 'punch' as the attention-getter in the introduction.

7. Collection of information and material

Once the outline of the presentation is developed, you can start gathering the relevant material. This is a time-consuming process and requires a fair amount of research. Information can generally be gathered from existing sources such as company resources or data, magazines, newspapers, and the Internet. Sometimes, you may need to do original research in the form of a survey to gather fresh data. For example, if you are making a presentation on a new product, you may have to conduct a survey to find out how consumers feel about that product concept and also about similar, competing products.

8. Organization of the body

The body of the presentation must always be prepared before the introduction. Organizing the body consists in identifying the key points that support your main idea and then selecting an organizational plan to develop these key points.

Let us take our earlier example of a sales presentation on a vacuum cleaner to prospective customers, where the key idea is to highlight that it is superior to competing brands. The main points, in this case, can be:

- It has greater cleaning power than other brands.
- It is more affordable.
- It is easier to use than other brands.

Once the main points are determined, sub-points can be developed to expand on each of these.

The next step is to choose an organizational plan to present these main and sub-points.

For example, in the case of a sales presentation a 'problem-solution' pattern or plan may be followed, where the customer is confronted with a problem and the product is offered as a solution to the problem.

9. Planning the introduction

Since the introduction is where you make the first impression, it must be planned with care. It must take up between 10 and 15 percent of your total speaking time. At the outset, you need to try and establish your credibility, by showing that you are qualified to speak on the subject of the presentation. An attention-getting opener must be developed, using techniques such as humor, dramatic questions, an interesting story, a quotation, or a startling statement.

For example, did you know that the number of road accidents last year touched the 100,000 marks?

Once audience attention is captured, the main idea must be stated clearly, followed by a preview of the entire presentation, so that people know what to expect.

10. Planning the conclusion

The conclusion of a presentation must be shorter than the introduction and occupy only 5 percent of the entire presentation. You must never introduce a new topic in the conclusion. Generally, every conclusion must have a review and a closing statement.

The review is essentially a reinforcement of the key idea and a summary of the main points. The main points can be enumerated, as in the outline of the presentation. The closing statement must be as strong as your opening statement so that your audience will remember the presentation. Therefore, the same techniques used to capture the audience's attention may also be used to prepare a good closing statement. In the case of persuasive presentations, the closing statement can include a call for immediate action.

For example: Now that you have seen what our vacuum cleaner can do, walk into our store today to place your order and avail yourself of an early bird discount!

11. Selection of a delivery style

Once your presentation is adequately prepared in terms of content, you also need to ensure that it will be delivered effectively, by selecting an appropriate style of delivery. Figure 2 depicts the five different delivery styles available to speakers.



Figure 2: Presentation Delivery Styles

- **Speaking impromptu –** In this case, the speaker is called upon to say a few words without any warning or advance notice. Since there is little or no time given for preparation, it is suited only for expert speakers. Impromptu speeches must be brief, simple, and direct, compared to prepared speeches.
- **Speaking extemporaneously –** This is different from speaking impromptu. While impromptu speeches are delivered on the spot and not rehearsed, an extemporaneous speech is prepared and rehearsed in advance. However, the speech is delivered naturally, without the support of

notes or other aids. This is the delivery style used by experienced professionals, who have sufficient knowledge of the subject to be able to speak without relying on notes.

- **Memorizing the presentation –** This is the least appealing style of delivery, as it comes across as unnatural and monotonous to the audience. Speakers who memories and deliver presentations word for word will also be at a disadvantage if they forget a part of the speech, as they will be unable to speak naturally.
- **Reading from written notes –** This involves reading the entire presentation from notes. It is a method used by government or business officials and may be appropriate when the material to be presented is highly technical or complex. However, it has some limitations. First, it gives the impression that the speech is very long and heavy. Secondly, it prevents the presenter from making eye contact with the audience.
- **Speaking from notes –** This is generally the most effective style of delivery. It involves jotting down the main ideas in point form on index cards and then referring to these cards merely as a trigger while speaking. If the main ideas are put down briefly on the cards, the speakers can elaborate on these ideas in their own words and speak for any length of time. The presentation is likely to be more effective since it comes across as natural and permits eye contact with the audience.

Along with these elements, the speaker must also ensure to maintain good voice quality during oral communication, as it creates a stage for healthy communication. As a speaker, you must ensure that you are audible to the listeners. Therefore, you must adjust the pitch and loudness of your voice accordingly.

SELF-ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS – 2

Match the following:	
4	Set A A. General purpose statement B. Quantified goal C. Audience size, age and gender D. Use of humor E. Trigger for speaking

	Set B A. Demographics B. To persuade C. Specific purpose statement D. Speaking from notes E. Opening and closing statements
Multiple Choice Questions:	
5	Where will you elaborate on the main points in a presentation? a) Introduction b) Body c) Conclusion d) Outline
True or False Questions:	
6	Speaking a few words without any warning or advance notice is called speaking extemporaneously. (True/False)

4.2 Using visual aids to support presentations

The use of visual aids enhances the effectiveness of a presentation and involves the audience more than a pure oral presentation. As the saying goes, "A picture is worth a thousand words". Several studies have indicated that presentations made with visual support have been more successful in persuading audiences than presentations without visuals. Visuals have also been found to make the information in presentations more memorable. In addition, graphics help speakers to illustrate ideas and to answer questions. However, visual aids must be used only where it is relevant and not just for the sake of using them. Since they may distract the attention of the audience from the speaker's main message.

A speaker has a wide variety of visual aids to choose from. Some of the commonly used types of visual aids are:

- Product demonstrations – Since "seeing believes", a sales presentation can be more effective and convince a prospective customer to try a product, if the product is shown in actual use.

- Photographs – Photographs are true to life and are an effective way of illustrating products. They are highly credible and can be used as proof to support facts.
- Diagrams – These are two-dimensional drawings that can convey information about size, shape, and structure – for example, floor plans.
- Lists and tables – These are an effective way of highlighting facts and figures and of making comparisons – for example, comparing last year's profits with this year's profits.
- Pie charts and graphs – Pie charts help to illustrate percentages of a single item – for example, the percentage of the total students in each area of specialization of an MBA program. Graphs are good for illustrating trends or growth in sales and profits over time.

Once the type of visual aid has been decided, the medium for presenting the visual aid needs to be selected. Again, a variety of media are available to the presenter. They are:

- Flip chart
- Transparencies
- PowerPoint slides
- Handouts
- Computerized displays
- Videotapes

Let us now discuss the relative advantages and disadvantages of each of these media and some guidelines for using them.

Flip chart

Flip chart consists of a large pad of thick chart paper attached to an easel, where different pictures are shown on separate charts one at a time, by turning the pages. At the end of the presentation, the charts can be flipped over to recap the session, hence the name 'flip chart'. Flip charts are commonly used during sales presentations and business meetings. They are easy to prepare, use, carry and set up. However, they are not suited for making a presentation to a large audience. They are also clumsy and can become worn out after repeated use. Figure 3 depicts a flip chart.



Figure 3: A Flip Chart

Transparencies

Transparencies are clear sheets used with an overhead projector to project an image on the screen. It is possible to transfer text or visuals from other sources to transparency by using a copy machine. It is also possible to write directly on the transparency with special marker pens, during the presentation.

Transparencies have a number of advantages. Unlike flip charts, they are better suited for large audiences. Unlike other visual aids, they are also easier and quicker to produce, since you can copy visuals from other sources, instead of creating them from scratch. You can also write on them as you speak and later erase what you have written and re-use them.

The disadvantage of using transparencies is that they are unmanageable and require an overhead projector. The speakers also have to position themselves in such a way that the projector does not block anyone's view.

Figure 4 depicts a transparency sheet.



Figure 4: Transparency Sheet

PowerPoint slides

PowerPoint slides are an effective visual aid as they lend a touch of sophistication and professionalism to the presentation. It is ideal for presentations where technical pictures and elaborate diagrams are

needed to illustrate ideas to the audience. PowerPoint slides are easy to store since they are less cumbersome than flip charts and transparencies. It is also possible to transfer photographs, logos, and other visuals directly onto the slide.

The use of laptop computers and presentation software such as Microsoft PowerPoint has made the creation of presentations very easy. You can easily add screens, and produce dramatic visuals, animation, and simulations to your presentation. Computer-based visuals created using PowerPoint have become a standard for most technical, educational, and business presentations. It can be used effectively for large and small audiences to convey simple as well as complex information.

The disadvantage of PowerPoint is that it tends to be overused for the sake of technology, 'gimmickry', and special effects. This tends to distract the attention of the audience from what the speaker is saying. Therefore, PowerPoint slides must be prepared carefully and used judiciously.

Figure 5 depicts a PowerPoint slide on Microsoft PowerPoint Presentation Window.



Figure 5: Microsoft Office PowerPoint Slide

Table 6.2 lists some dos and don'ts of preparing and using PowerPoint slides for presentations.

Table 2: Checkpoints for Using Power Point Slides

1. Do not make the layout of the PowerPoint slides too cluttered orcrowded.
2. Do not prepare too many or too few slides. Around 12 slides aresufficient for a one-hour presentation.
3. Plan to spend about 2 – 3 minutes talking on each slide, excludingthe title and outline of the presentation.

4. Pay attention to the font size, number of words and number of lines on a slide. Seven words per sentence and Seven lines per slide is a general rule of thumb.
5. Make the slides look sober and dignified and do not make thebackground too flashy.
6. Ensure that the style and format used in the slides are consistent.
7. Make the text on the slide crisp, avoiding unnecessary articles andprepositions. Choose key words and phrases, instead of long sentences.
8. Add value to what is on the slide, by explaining key points. Avoidreading directly from the slide.
9. Balance the time spent on each slide. Do not spend too much timeon some slides and rush through the rest.
10. Coordinate your explanation with the slide numbers.
11. Focus on the main points mentioned in the slides. Avoid needlessfrills and trivialities.

Additional References:

- http://www.presentationmagazine.com/powerpoint.htm
- http://www.lifehack.org/articles/technology/10-tips-for-more-effective-powerpoint-presentations.html
- http://www.microsoft.com/atwork/skills/presentations.aspx

Handouts

Handouts are printed details on the topic of the presentation that are distributed to the audience. They have the advantage of providing a permanent record of your ideas. They also provide extra information which you may not be able to cover during your oral presentation. For example, if you are making a presentation on a new product, the technical features of the product, along with some illustrations, could be included in the handout for the audience to study later. Handouts can also reduce the need for the listeners to take notes during your presentation. This way, their attention will be completely focused on what you are saying.

One problem with handouts is that the audience may read them during your presentation, instead of listening to your presentation. You can avoid this by asking them to read the handouts later or by distributing the handouts at the end of the session.

Figure 6 depicts sample handouts.

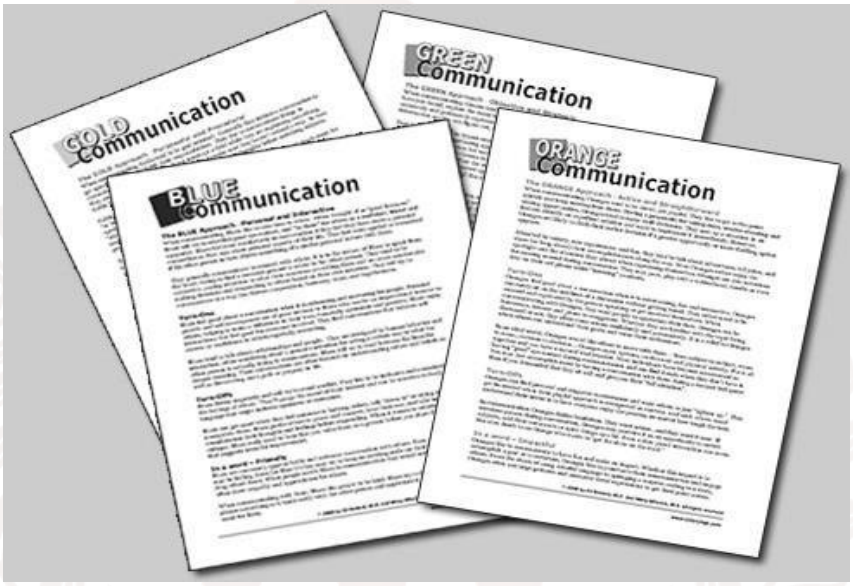


Figure 6: Handouts

Computerized displays

Computerized displays are images stored on your own computer screen or laptop, which can be shown to the audience to illustrate your ideas. This is an inexpensive and convenient type of visual aid and requires little effort or

advance preparation. However, it is suitable only for small audiences, due to its small size. You can use a computerized display to make a presentation to a large audience by using a Liquid Crystal Display (LCD) projector to project the images onto a big screen. Figure 7 depicts a computerized display using an LCD.



Figure 7: Computerized Display

CDs and DVDs

Initially, videotapes were used as audio-visual aids to exploit the attention-grabbing properties of television for maximum impact. Compact Discs (CDs) and Digitally Versatile Discs (DVDs) are used instead of videotapes nowadays for the same. Using CDs and DVDs for a presentation can add value when you wish to illustrate action – for example, to show a sportsperson in action, a product demonstration in a TV commercial, or a speaker's gestures. However, like other visual aids, they must not be used for the sake of entertainment. Attention must also be paid to producing them carefully, to make sure that the quality is of a high standard.

Figure 8 depicts CDs and videotape.



Figure 8: CDs and Videotape

No matter what type of visual aid you choose to support your presentation, some basic rules need to be followed when using them. They are:

- **Use visual aids only if they add value –** Make sure that you have a reason to use a visual, rather than using it for its own sake. If your ideas are better explained through words, avoid the visuals since this will only distract the attention of the audience.
- **Match your visuals with the level of the audience –** Your visual aid's level of sophistication must depend on your audience. For example, if you are making a presentation to top

management, the graphics must be extremely polished. For less formal presentations, simple graphics created on your own computer or laptop may be sufficient.

- **Make the visuals clear and large enough –** Avoid creating visuals that are so small that they have to be described. It is better to use no visual support than using visuals that cannot be seen.
- **Make the visuals simple –** When creating visuals, avoid making them too complicated and detailed, so that the audience can understand them without difficulty.
- **Avoid too much text with visuals –** Visuals must have short captions, using only key-words and simple typefaces, so that attention is drawn to the visual alone.
- **Give each visual a title and number –** For the sake of easy identification, make sure that each visual is given an appropriate caption and is numbered.
- **Show a visual only when you discuss it –** Revealing a visual before you are ready to describe it will only distract the attention of the audience from what you are presently saying.
- **Remove visuals after use –** Similarly, blank out, erase or turn off visuals soon after you have explained to them so that the audience can focus on what you are saying next.
- **Check if visuals will work beforehand –** Remember to check all the facilities in the presentation room before the session, to ensure that the visuals can be shown without any problem.
- **Rehearse setting up visuals –** Practice using the visuals before the presentation, so that you are familiar with the sequence of when to show and remove them, without any confusion.

Activity - 1

Attend any presentation of your choice where the speaker uses visual support. Evaluate its effectiveness, based on what was discussed in this unit. What feedback and suggestions would you give the speaker, regarding the use of visual aids?
(Refer section 3 for detailed guidelines.)

Additional Reference:

Guffey, M. E., Loewy, D. (2010). Essentials of Business Communication, pp 333-370. USA: South-Western Cengage Learning.

Don'ts in a Business Presentation

- Don't read word by word from your script. You will sound like a robot and miss the all-important eye contact with the audience. Instead use stiff cue cards with key words and starter sentences.
- Don't talk too fast and try to reduce a 45-minute presentation into a 30-minute presentation by speaking quickly.
- Never use acronyms without spelling them out and explaining what they mean.
- Don't use complete sentences on your presentation slides. You must orally present the information and the slides must only support it.
- Don't use hard-to-read fonts or garish backgrounds that obscure the text.
- Don't use cute or unusual photos that are not illustrating exactly what you are talking about. It distracts the audience and they might miss what you are saying.
- Don't waste your audience's time by presenting the history and structure of your organisation in business presentation. Do it only if it is essential for the audience to understand your presentation.
- Don't hide behind the computer or speaker stand. Make sure that the audience can see you and maintain eye contact with them.

SELF-ASSESSMENT QUESTIONS – 3

True or False Questions:	
7	Visuals make the information in presentations more memorable. (True/False)
8	It is good practice to blank out, erase, or turn off visuals soon after you have explained to them so that the audience can focus attention on what you are saying next. (True/False)
Multiple Choice Questions:	
9	_____are clear sheets used with an overhead projector to project an image on the screen. (Pick the right option) a) Transparencies b) Flip charts c) Power Points d) Handouts
Fill in the blanks:	

10	Name the audio-visual aids that exploit the attention getting properties of television for maximum impact.

5. SUMMARY

Let us recapitulate the important concepts discussed in this unit:

- There are two types of oral communication: oral face-to-face communication and oral non-face-to-face communication.
- Oral presentation is a powerful way of conveying information and ideas in business communication.
- The type of presentation is chosen based on the purpose of the presentation and the audience.
- The steps to develop an effective presentation are as follows:
  - Definition of the purpose of the presentation
  - Development of the key idea
  - Audience analysis
  - Analysis of yourself as a speaker
  - Analysis of the circumstances
  - Preparation of outline
  - Collection of information and material
  - Organization of the body
  - Planning the introduction
  - Planning the conclusion
  - Selection of a delivery style
- The use of visual aids such as product demonstrations, photographs, diagrams, lists and tables, and pie charts and graphs increase the effectiveness of the presentation.
- A wide variety of media such as flip charts, transparencies, Power Point, handouts, computerized displays, and videotapes are used by the speakers for presentation.

6. GLOSSARY

Compact Disc (CD)	-	An optical disc used to store digital data.
Digital Versatile Disc (DVD)	-	A small plastic disc used for the storage of digital data. It has very high storage memory compared to CDs.
Easel	-	An upright frame for displaying or supporting something, such as an artist's canvas.
Impromptu	-	Totally unprepared.
Liquid Crystal Display (LCD) projector	-	It is a type of video projector for displaying video, images or computer data on a screen or other flat surface.
Overhead Projector	-	It is a machine that displays images onto a screen with a light and mirror system.
Teleconference	-	It is a telephone or video meeting between participants in two or more locations.

7. TERMINAL QUESTIONS

1. Name the two categories of oral communication. Explain them.
2. List any five types of presentations with examples and their target audience.
3. What information will you gather during audience analysis? Explain.
4. Explain the different delivery styles that speakers can select for their presentation.
5. What are the various visual aids that speakers can use in their presentations?

8. ANSWERS

Self-Assessment Questions

1. False. Conflicts between co-workers cannot be resolved through teleconferencing.
2. True
3. Teleconferencing
4. A – 2, B - 3, C – 1, D – 5, E – 4
5. (b) Body
6. False. The speaker is called upon to say a few words without any warning or advance notice is called speaking impromptu.
7. True
8. True
9. (a) Transparencies
10. Videotapes

Terminal Questions Answers

Answer 1: Oral communication is categorized into two types based on the type of interaction. They are oral face-to-face communication and oral non-face- to-face communication. For more details, refer to section 2.

Answer 2: Presentations may be of different types and purposes depending on the type of audience. Presentations can be made for orientation, briefing, or for training. For more details, refer to table 1 in section 3.

Answer 3: During audience analysis some of the information you gather before you begin your presentation is:

- Job designations and areas of expertise
- Preferred style of presentation
- Demographic characteristics of the audience
- Size of the audience

For more details, refer to sub-section 3.1.

Answer 4: The different delivery styles that a speaker can adopt are as follows:

- Speaking impromptu
- Speaking extemporaneously
- Memorizing the presentation
- Reading from written notes
- Speaking from notes

For more details, refer to sub-section 3.1.

Answer 5: Speakers can make use of visual aids such as product demonstrations, photographs, diagrams, lists and tables, and pie charts and graphs in their presentation. For more details, refer to sub-section 3.2.

9. CASE STUDY

PCA Training Approach for PCT

Issue

Powerful Communication Associates (PCA) were approached by Jane Mackie, Head of Training and OD, Commissioning to conduct communication skill development courses for the Executive team of the Commissioning Arm of the PCT in St. Margaret's Hospital.

The executives of the hospital were highly dedicated and experienced professionals who were extremely good at their work. The challenge for PCA was to enhance the skills of the executives and prepare them to handle wide range of demanding and stressful communication situations for example, communicating with the public, with patients, the media, at conferences, at meetings etc.

Approach

PCA explored in detail the individual roles and professional challenges of the executives. PCA also looked for the possible future demands that can arise for which the executives had to be prepared. After much thought and discussion, PCA devised a course to suit the needs of PCT.

PCA was very much aware of the fact that audience usually judge a speaker by the manner and style of his/her speech. The training sessions developed was a practical one that focused on the physical, emotional and intellectual demands of speaking in public. The training also emphasised the need for a speaker to come prepared before the speech. During the training relevant exercises for posture, breathing, vocal tone, clarity and delivery style were demonstrated and exercised to enhance the effectiveness of communication. The main aim of the training was to bring a balance between the speaker's style of presentation and substance of the speech.

Result

The training proved to be very effective. The communication standard of the hospital staff who participated in the training programme had increased and they sounded highly professional. Each individual, by themselves, had found a style and approach which suited them to communicate effectively with the public, with patients and the media. This made them to communicate more confidently and effectively.

Discussion Questions:

1. Why did Jane Mackie approach PCA?

(Hint: Refer to the section Issue in the Case Study)

2. Explain how PCA met the requirements of PCT.

(Hint: Refer to the section Approach in the Case Study)

(Source: http://www.powerful-communication.com/case-study-nhs-west-essex- pct.htm)

10. REFERENCES

References:

- Guffey, M.E., & Rhodes, K. (2009). Business Communication: Process and Product. USA: Nelson Education Ltd.
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